

THE CLEARING - AI Fatigue Recovery Checklist

For software engineers who are shipping more and learning less.

Check all that apply. The more checked, the more intentional recovery needs to be.

PART 1: Are You Experiencing AI Fatigue?

- ☐ I can't remember the last time I built something from scratch without AI.
- ☐ I feel productive but not satisfied with my work.
- ☐ Sunday dread doesn't match the actual difficulty of Monday.
- ☐ I can't explain why AI-generated code works the way it does.
- ☐ I've noticed gaps in skills I used to have cold confidence in.
- ☐ I'm learning less week over week while shipping more.
- ☐ I feel like a coordinator between AI outputs and actual work.
- ☐ The gap between 'working' and 'building' has become noticeable.
- ☐ I'm considering leaving tech - not because of workload, but because the work feels hollow.
- ☐ I feel guilty for being ungrateful for AI tools that make me tired.

SCORE INTERPRETATION

- 1-3** Mild fatigue - you are managing, but watch for escalation.
- 4-6** Real fatigue - time to build in recovery practices.
- 7-10** Deep fatigue - this checklist is your starting point, not your whole plan.

PART 2: 30-Day Recovery Practices

A. DAILY NON-NEGOTIABLES (do every weekday)

- ☐ 20 minutes of no-AI coding (before 10am if possible)
- ☐ Explain one piece of AI code out loud before accepting it
- ☐ Note one gap between what AI did and what you would have done
- ☐ End of day: write one sentence about what you built today (not shipped)

B. WEEKLY RESET (once per week)

- ☐ 90-minute deep work block: build something small, no AI
- ☐ Review your 'AI gaps logged' - count them, notice patterns
- ☐ Read one part of a codebase you own without AI assist
- ☐ Ask: Could I build my current project core feature from scratch?

C. SIGNS YOU NEED A BIGGER RESET

- ☐ Sleep disruption from work anxiety
- ☐ Physical symptoms (back pain, headaches, eye strain) increasing
- ☐ Dread building before weekends, not just Sundays
- ☐ Skills you used to trust - debugging, architecture, reading code - feeling shaky
- ☐ You've stopped explaining code to yourself out loud

If 3+ of Section C signs are true: This checklist is not enough.

Visit clearing-ai.com/mental-health.html for professional support resources - therapists, crisis lines, and EAP contacts.